

Instructor Guide

Lesson Metadata

- **Path:** Digital Independence Path
- **Course:** 16 — Build Your Professional Identity
- **Lesson:** 2 of course — "Define Your Strengths and Direction"
- **Age band:** 15–18
- **Format:** Live, instructor-led, virtual classroom
- **Duration:** 60 minutes
- **Prerequisite:** Lesson 1 — Digital Identity Audit (students must arrive with their audit notes: a list of every public/semi-public trace of their work — GitHub repos, Lumexa project submissions, Canva designs, any deployed Vercel sites)
- **Tools referenced:** GitHub, Google Docs, Vercel, Canva (no new tool setup required this lesson — this is a thinking/writing lesson)
- **Materials students need:** Their Lesson 1 audit notes, the Worksheet (Strengths & Direction Map), a Google Doc or paper to write in

Overview

Lesson 1 helped students see what already exists online about them as a builder. This lesson turns that raw inventory into something usable: an honest read on what they're actually good at and interested in, and a believable focus area (a "direction") to build their portfolio around for the rest of Course 16.

The core danger this lesson guards against is **fabrication** — students claiming expertise they don't have because they think a portfolio needs to look impressive. The core skill this lesson teaches is **honest self-assessment**: separating what excites them, what they're actually decent at, and what they can prove with a finished artifact — and picking a direction from the overlap, not from wishful thinking.

By the end of the lesson, every student leaves with a completed Strengths & Direction Map: a project inventory, a strengths cluster, and a one-to-two-sentence direction statement they will use as the spine of their portfolio for the rest of the course.

Instructor Prep (before class)

- Re-read your own copy of the fictional example (Jordan R., used in the Student Lesson and Worksheet) so you can reference it fluently during the live demo — don't read it cold in front of students.
 - Have 2–3 real (anonymized or consented) examples from past cohorts ready as backup illustrations, if your program allows reusing past student work with permission. If not, rely on the Jordan R. example only.
 - Skim each student's Lesson 1 audit notes beforehand if your platform gives you visibility into submissions. Flag students who had thin or empty audits — they'll need extra 1:1 support during the activity, since this lesson assumes Lesson 1 material to work from.
 - Open a blank Google Doc or slide to run the live demo in front of students (see Live Demo script below).
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Teaching Sequence

1. Hook and Framing (5 min)

Open with a direct question to the group: *"If someone you'd never met looked at your GitHub and Lumexa projects right now, what would they think you're good at?"* Take 2–3 quick verbal answers. Don't correct them yet — just collect impressions.

Frame the lesson: *"Today we're not inventing a personality. We're reading the evidence you already have — from Lesson 1 — and figuring out, honestly, what it actually shows. Then we're going to pick ONE thing to focus on for your portfolio. Not forever. Just for now."*

2. Direct Teach: Interest vs. Strength vs. Proven Skill (10 min)

Introduce the three-tier framework (full definitions are in the Student Lesson glossary — teach them here, don't just assign reading):

- **Interest** — something you enjoy or are curious about. No evidence required. ("I think game design is cool.")
- **Strength** — something you are noticeably better at, or pick up faster, or get better feedback on, compared to other things you've tried. Some evidence, but maybe not a finished product. ("I always finish the CSS/layout parts of group projects faster than teammates.")
- **Proven skill** — something you can point to a *finished, working artifact* to demonstrate. ("Here is a deployed Vercel site I built and styled myself.")

Key talking point: **a portfolio should lead with proven skills, be supported by strengths, and can gesture at interests as "what I want to learn next" — never the reverse.** Claiming an interest as a proven skill is the fabrication trap this lesson exists to prevent.

Say explicitly: *"You can be interested in ten things. You can be honestly strong at three or four. You can only prove what you've actually shipped. Today we sort your own stuff into those three buckets."*

3. Live Demo: Reading a Fictional Student's Project List (15 min)

Use the fictional student "**Jordan R.**" (clearly narrate to students that this is made up, not a real classmate). Walk through it live in a doc so students see your thinking, not just a finished answer.

Demo script:

Display this project list (or recreate it live):

1. Lumexa Mission: "Build a Space Weather Dashboard" — used HTML/CSS, styled with Canva graphics, deployed to Vercel
2. Lumexa Mission: "Simple Platformer Game" — built in a block-based/JS engine, finished but buggy jump mechanic
3. Personal project: redesigned little sister's birthday invitation in Canva, shared with family
4. Lumexa Mission: "Personal Portfolio Starter Page" — HTML/CSS only, deployed to Vercel, got positive instructor feedback on layout
5. Group project: helped a teammate debug their color scheme and spacing in a CSS project (not their own repo)

Narrate the extraction out loud: - "Project 1 and 4 are both HTML/CSS, both deployed, both got positive feedback. That's a *pattern* — that's strength evidence, not a one-time fluke." - "Project 2 is a real finished game, but Jordan says the jump mechanic is buggy and this is their only game project. That's an *interest with early proof* — not yet a strength cluster, since there's only one data point and it's incomplete." - "Project 3 and 5 both involve visual/layout judgment — Canva design and CSS styling help. That's reinforcing the same thread as 1 and 4: visual/front-end layout is a repeating strength, showing up in multiple contexts, not just one lucky project." - "So what's the honest direction? Not 'game developer' — one buggy game isn't enough evidence, and it would be a stretch to claim it. The evidence points to **front-end web development / visual design**, because it shows up three separate times, across different tools, with outside positive feedback."

Land the point: *"Jordan is genuinely interested in game dev too — that's fine, that's real, and it can go in the 'what I still want to learn' section. But the portfolio direction has to follow the evidence, not the excitement."*

4. Guided Activity (20 min)

Students open their Worksheet and Lesson 1 audit notes and work through, in order:

1. **Project inventory table** — list every Lumexa mission and personal project, what it demonstrates, and a confidence level (see Worksheet).
2. **Strengths clustering** — group projects that repeat the same skill or theme.
3. **Direction statement** — write 1–2 honest sentences naming a focus area, using the template.
4. **What I still want to learn** — park genuine interests that aren't yet provable.

Circulate (or use breakout support in a virtual room) during steps 1–2 especially — this is where students either freeze (nothing to list) or overclaim (list projects they didn't really contribute to). See Common Misconceptions and Student Difficulties below for how to intervene.

5. Share-Out and Discussion (7 min)

Ask 2–3 volunteers to read their direction statement aloud. After each, ask the group: *"What evidence from their project list backs that up?"* This keeps peer feedback focused on evidence, not enthusiasm.

Discussion questions: - Was there a project on your list you almost left off because it felt "too small" to count? Why did you decide to include or exclude it? - Did your direction statement match what you expected before you did the inventory, or did the evidence point somewhere different? - What's one thing on your "still want to learn" list that you're excited about but not ready to claim yet? - How would you feel if someone asked you to prove your direction statement right now, using only what's already built? What would you show them?

6. Lesson Close (3 min)

Recap: *"You now have a direction — not a permanent label, a current focus. Next lesson, we start building the actual portfolio around it. Keep your Worksheet — you'll use your direction statement directly in the next lesson."*

Remind students: a direction can change later as they build more projects. This lesson is about starting from honest evidence, not locking in a life choice.

Common Misconceptions

- **"I have to pick just one thing forever."** Correct this directly: a direction is a *current focus for this portfolio*, not a permanent identity. Students can and will revise it as they build more. Point to the "what I still want to learn" section as proof the door stays open.
- **"I need to be the best at something to claim it as a strength."** Reframe: a strength is relative to *their own* other work and effort, not a competition against other students or professionals. "Noticeably better than your other attempts" is the bar, not "best in class."
- **"If I only have school/Lumexa projects and nothing personal, I don't have a real direction."** Lumexa mission work counts fully as evidence. Reassure students that assigned project work is legitimate proof of skill — professionals build portfolios from work-for-hire and coursework too.
- **"My direction has to be a job title."** Directions like "front-end web dev" are fine, but so are more specific or blended ones ("data visualization," "game UI design," "creative coding"). Don't force students into a narrow set of labels.

Student Difficulties and Troubleshooting

- **Empty or thin project list (thin Lesson 1 audit):** Prompt with specific questions — "Have you ever fixed a bug for a friend? Made anything in Canva, even for fun? Started something you didn't finish?" Unfinished or informal work can still go in the inventory with an honest confidence level; it just can't be the sole basis for a direction.
- **Overclaiming group contributions:** If a student lists a group project as if they built the whole thing, ask "What part did you personally do?" and have them note that specific part in the "what it demonstrates" column, not the whole project.

- **Underclaiming out of modesty:** Some students, especially after Lesson 1's identity audit, become overly cautious and won't claim anything as a strength. Point them back to repeated patterns across 2+ projects as the objective test, not a feeling of confidence.
 - **Direction statement too vague ("I like coding"):** Push for the pattern behind it — ask "What part of coding, specifically, keeps showing up in your projects?" and have them revise using the template's sentence structure.
 - **Direction statement too broad/fabricated ("I'm a full-stack AI game developer"):** Ask them to point to the specific finished projects backing each part of that claim. If they can't, walk it back together to what the evidence actually supports.
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How to Review Student Work

When checking a student's completed Worksheet, confirm:

1. **Inventory table has real entries** pulled from their actual Lesson 1 audit, not invented projects.
2. **Confidence levels are honest** — not everything marked "high confidence."
3. **Strengths cluster is evidence-based** — at least one cluster should reference 2+ projects, not a single one-off.
4. **Direction statement is specific and backed by the inventory** — you should be able to point at 2–3 rows in their table that justify it.
5. **"Still want to learn" section is present and distinct from the direction statement** — shows they understand the interest/strength/proven-skill distinction rather than collapsing everything into one claim.

If a direction statement is unsupported or fabricated-sounding, don't reject it publicly — follow up privately or in the next 1:1 check-in and walk them back through the evidence together.